

Mengnan (Monica) Xu

(512) 808-6808 mengnanxu2333@gmail.com

PhD Candidate, Public Management, Beijing Normal University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Chinese politics and governance; state capacity and organizational mobilization; development governance; China's poverty alleviation programs; AI and computational methods for social science; political economy of China; South–South cooperation and international development.

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Candidate (ABD), Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Government</i>	<i>Oct 2018 – May 2023</i> Beijing, China
Master of Public Management <i>Beijing Normal University, School of Government</i>	<i>Sep 2016 – Jun 2018</i> Beijing, China
Master of Science, Information Technology and Management <i>University of Texas at Austin, McCombs School of Business</i>	<i>Jul 2023 – May 2024</i> Austin, TX, USA
Bachelor of Arts, Management Information Systems <i>Central South University</i>	<i>Sep 2008 – Jun 2012</i> Changsha, China

Doctoral Dissertation (in progress):

Organizational Ecology and the Formation of China's Development Governance Knowledge System: Evidence from the National Targeted Poverty Alleviation Program, 2000–2020.
Beijing Normal University, School of Government.

PUBLICATIONS & WORKING PAPERS

- Xu, Mengnan**, Robert Walker, and Lichao Yang. “Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China.” *Journal of Contemporary China*, 31(137): 756–775, 2022. (SSCI Q1; **First Author**)
- Xiaoxin Xu, Xiulan Zhang, Teh Wei Hu, Leonard S. Miller, and **Mengnan Xu**. “Effects of Global and Domestic Tobacco Control Policies on Cigarette Consumption Per Capita: An Evaluation Using Monthly Data in China.” *BMJ Open*, 9(9): 1–9, 2019. (SCIE; Fifth Author)
- Xiulan Zhang, Xiaoxin Xu, **Mengnan Xu**, and Teh-wei Hu. “The Impact of Tobacco Taxation Policy on Slim Cigarette Use and the Growing Popularity of Slim Cigarettes in China Since 2014.” *Health*, 11(11): 711–720, 2019. (Third Author)
- Xu, Mengnan**. “Organizational Ecology and Multi-Actor State Mobilization in China's Poverty Alleviation Governance.” *Working paper, under revision*.
- Xu, Mengnan**. “Computational Methods for Large-Scale Chinese Policy Document Analysis: A Text-as-Data Approach to Governance Research.” *Working paper, in preparation*.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Technical Research Analyst

Sep 2016 – May 2023

Gates Foundation–Funded Research Initiative, Beijing Normal University

Beijing, China

- Led end-to-end coordination of multi-year research programs on development governance and public administration reform, aligning international funding requirements with academic deliverables.
- Designed and executed large-scale quantitative and qualitative data collection; performed statistical analysis using Python and SQL to support policy recommendations.
- Built an original organizational ecology database tracking actors, resource flows, and governance logic across China’s national poverty alleviation program (2000–2020), drawing on provincial yearbooks, government reports, and policy documents.
- Applied NLP pipelines (topic modeling, named-entity recognition, keyword co-occurrence networks) to Chinese-language policy corpora exceeding 10,000 documents.
- Translated empirical findings into policy briefs and analytical reports for program leadership and external stakeholders.
- Managed annual planning, milestone tracking, and cross-institutional coordination across government, university, and foundation partners.

Graduate Research Assistant, Public Management

Sep 2016 – Jun 2018

Beijing Normal University, School of Government

Beijing, China

- Conducted literature reviews, archival research, and comparative policy analysis on Chinese governance, state-society relations, and public administration.
- Contributed to faculty research projects examining central–local government relations and organizational reform in China.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

[Teaching assistant roles or courses taught at Beijing Normal University may be listed here.]

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“Organizational Participation and State Governance in China’s Poverty Alleviation Program.” Annual Conference, Chinese Association of Public Administration, 2022.

“Computational Approaches to Analyzing Chinese Policy Documents.” Workshop on Computational Social Science, Beijing Normal University, 2021.

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer / AI Engineer

Jun 2025 – Mar 2026

Apple Inc.

Austin, TX, USA

- Developed components for Apple’s Intelligence platform, focusing on production-scale natural language processing pipelines and retrieval-augmented generation architectures.
- Applied large language model techniques to large-scale information processing and knowledge integration systems, gaining first-hand engineering experience with the tools now central to computational social

science.

Software Engineer
AOI

Apr 2026 – Present
Austin, TX, USA

- Built full-pipeline automated data monitoring and analytics system for manufacturing execution processes.
- Designed modules for large-scale data collection, cleaning, and multi-dimensional statistical analysis.

Senior Risk Analyst
Agricultural Bank of China

Jul 2012 – Jun 2016
Hengyang, China

- Extracted and analyzed large-scale financial datasets using SQL and statistical modeling to support risk management and policy analytics.
- Developed credit scoring models (logistic regression, WOE binning) that reduced default rates and improved loan processing efficiency.

METHODOLOGICAL AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

Quantitative and Computational Methods: Regression analysis, difference-in-differences, network analysis, causal inference; Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), R, SQL, STATA/SAS.

AI and NLP for Social Science: Large language models (fine-tuning, retrieval-augmented generation, prompt engineering), topic modeling (LDA, BERTopic), named-entity recognition, text classification, word embeddings; LangChain, OpenAI API, Hugging Face.

Data Infrastructure: AWS (S3, Lambda, SageMaker), BigQuery, MySQL, MongoDB; Git, Jupyter, Tableau, Power BI.

Research Methods: Archival and documentary analysis, qualitative case study, elite interviews, survey research.

LANGUAGES

Mandarin Chinese	Native
English	Proficient (academic writing, presentations, and publication)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.